

eyeballs translate into advertiser interest and a commercial windfall. According to a KPMG report, cricket accounted for 85 per cent of all revenue in the Indian sports sponsorship market in 2025, with men's cricket drawing the lion's share.

If viewership is directly proportional to sponsorship, the direction in which women's cricket in India is heading is clear.

That is what Tuhin Mishra, CEO of Baseline Ventures, which manages several top Indian athletes across sports, believes.

Tuhin adds that while the Women's Cricket World Cup was historic, it only reinforced an already established trend. "There's no two ways about it. If men's cricket is the biggest sport in the country, women's cricket is clearly the second biggest sport in India. I don't think it was a matter of India winning the World Cup to make this point. I think it's already happened a while back," he says.

The numbers back him. According to KPMG, the media rights valuation for the first cycle of the Women's Premier League, the women's counterpart to the IPL, is 951 crore, with the BCCI stating that it earned 377 crore from the WPL in its first season in 2023. Even by itself, the WPL accounts for about three per cent of the revenue of the entire Indian sports market, making it the richest league in India outside the IPL.

According to Tuhin, women's cricket already has the highest-paid women sportspersons in the country. "We have been managing Smriti Mandhana for the last eight years, and I can say that for the last three, she has been the highest-paid female athlete in the country. This is from before the World Cup. She might endorse a few more now, but she was already endorsing 16 brands before the World Cup win," he says.

With money and fame flowing in, the future of women's cricket in India looks bright. The outlook is less certain for non-cricket women's sport. In recent years, women athletes in what were traditionally termed Olympic sports (a label now blurred by cricket's inclusion in the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics) have contributed significantly to India's performance at the highest levels. Since 2012, women have won nine of India's 21 Olympic medals while forming nearly 40 per cent (175 of 429) of the

contingent. But while their numbers have grown, doubts remain about whether non-cricket sports can compete, both financially and in attracting talent.

Uncertain future

The general sentiment is that women's sport in India is likely to be dominated by women's cricket, with other sports appearing less promising to prospective talent.

"I think this World Cup win will be a pivotal moment for women's sport and of course it will be dominated by women's cricket," says Divyanshu Singh, CEO of JSW Sports, which owns a WPL team (Delhi Capitals) and a women's hockey team (Soorma Hockey Club), and also operates the Inspire Institute of Sport that trains male and female athletes in Olympic disciplines such as track and field, boxing, wrestling and judo.

"It's brilliant that India have a World Cup champion in women's cricket. But even before that, we have had World Champions in women's sport," Singh says. "I was looking at the numbers and we have had 23 women's World Champions across boxing (Nikhat Zareen, Lovlina Borgohain, Mary Kom), weightlifting (Karnam Malleswari, Mirabai Chanu, Bindyarani Devi), shooting (Tejaswini Sawant), and badminton (P.V. Sindhu). In some of these sports, the global level of competition is certainly a lot tougher than it is in cricket, which only a few countries play competitively. But relatively few of these world champions are household names," he says.

The reason comes down to visibility. "When you look at what we call Olympic sports, the only real time these get visibility is during the Olympics and to a smaller extent, the Asian and Commonwealth Games. They often aren't on TV at all. Some of them don't compete through the season or don't have regular high-profile competition like the WPL for women cricketers," says Tuhin.

Lower visibility leads to lower commercial prospects and, potentially, lower participation.

Women's cricket coach Ashwani Singh has seen such shifts before. "When I was a young boy in the 1970s and 1980s, cricket was just one of many sports that kids played. Football was popular, and field hockey was considered the national game. Then we won the World Cup in 1983, and slowly cricket started gaining popularity. It took off completely in 2003 when money started coming into the sport. Now compare where men's cricket and men's hockey are. Cricket is everywhere and men's hockey is struggling," says Ashwani, coach of

Transformative triumph: India's World Cup-winning squad celebrates in Navi Mumbai, its breakthrough victory sending ripples far beyond cricket. GETTY IMAGES